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Struggle for change in a Nubian community

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Walking in the village one afternoon, Hussein and I met Hakim Kamel, a villager who, in the perfunctory formula of the area, asked us in for tea. Aware that the invitation was not meant to be accepted, we nevertheless accepted with alacrity, our rudeness born of desperation, so overjoyed were we at having finally been invited into a home. Visibly embarrassed, Hakim led us into his guest room while his wife hastily prepared tea—a small event but for us a heart-lifting breakthrough, as soon afterward all the families in the village would be vying with one another to invite us in their turn. To be sure, there were some who maintained until the day we left Kanuba that we were spies, but these were a small minority. In general, people began to realize that no great purpose was served by concealment. Among those who saw us as fitting in with their plans to publicize the village, there were a few who expected us to bring about tangible benefits as well.

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As field work progressed, I came to realize that many of the changes taking place in the village were being engineered largely by one man, Shatr Shalashil. This had not been immediately apparent because we had been told that other older men, such as Sheikh Muhammad and Hag Abdullah (the imam of the mosque) were the village leaders and that Shatr had originally been summoned to deal with us only because, having lived a long time in Cairo, he had had contact and experience with strangers before. In addition, Shatr's personal qualities did not correspond to our stereotypes of leadership. He seemed timid and vacillating rather than aggressive and decisive, and he often played the clown, making people laugh at or with him. He was the butt

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of much ridicule and joking and always publicly disavowed any desire for leadership or authority. It took months before we discerned that behind the clownish and dissembling mask was a clever, ambitious leader playing multiple roles while exercising a decisive influence on all decisions of village importance.

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A good part of this book is devoted to Shatr's own account of his life and views, and it is in that respect a kind of autobiography. The life history is an old established genre in anthropology, and many of those to be found in the literature are of outstanding quality, not only as fine literature but in providing insight into a society's inner workings and a window on the meanings that life in a particular cultural setting has for the particular actor.³ At the same time, however, much potential insight may be lost to the reader who lacks knowledge of the sociocultural setting and historical background of the events described. For this reason, I have placed Shatr's life story and philosophical observations, within the cultural and historical framework of a particular Nubian village in Egypt, hoping that this will not only make his own actions more intelligible but will provide another set of data relating to how Nubian culture is perceived and used by its members during a period of significant change.

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3. See L.L. Langness, *The Life History in Anthropological Science*.

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